

Change Is a Must: The Physics for Positive Change, Featuring Steve Olson

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We've already learned that Pat Summitt insisted on respect – respect for oneself and for others – all others, including your opponents. That was Pat's first principle. And it has to be ours, too. So, what does respect have to do with change? In short, everything. Here's why. Teams and groups, like whole organizations and whole societies, don't really change until they are taken out of their comfort zone long enough to begin discarding the beliefs, attitudes, and habits that no longer work.

The technical term for being out of our comfort zones is disequilibrium. As the stress of being pushed out of our comfort zones goes up, so does our performance, but only to a point. Too much disequilibrium and our learning and performance starts to degrade. So, changing requires that we modulate the stress of being pushed to become better, slowly raising our performance over time.

A leader is someone who uses the forces of disequilibrium to get people to change for the better. Pat Summitt was the master of managing disequilibrium. She was forever forcing her players out of their comfort zones in order to spur them to become better. That's because, just like you and me, even great players naturally want to return to low levels of disequilibrium. But Pat wouldn't let them. She'd make them play other positions. She'd make them run and run and run again until they thought they couldn't run anymore. And then she'd run them some more. She'd make them practice and practice, staying all over her players until they got it right. Only then were her players ready to replace their old beliefs about what they were capable of and their old habits with better beliefs and better attitudes and better habits.

In other words, Pat knew that none of us will change until we really feel and really believe that the status quo won't work anymore. We know we are going to have to learn. We know we are going to have to change. But the reason that Pat Summitt could do this was because she knew that, as a leader, her job was not to be liked by her players. She knew that her job was to be disliked by them at a rate that they could tolerate. Pat's job was to keep her players in what leadership scholars call the *productive zone of disequilibrium* long enough to change their game.